

MISUNDERSTANDING THE LOCAL SIGNS

colonial encounters

▼ Herbal cure

This illustration reproduced from an Aztec physician's 1552 codex shows the *nonochton*, a herbal remedy for heart pains, in which the plants' petals were ground up in water and drunk as a juice. Colonizers were often skeptical of local medicine.

The influx of Europeans from the late 15th century into areas of the Americas, Africa, and Asia, where indigenous beliefs had previously thrived, led to a clash of cultures. Colonizers often sweepingly called traditional religions magic and their rituals devil worship, and persecuted its practitioners.

The Portuguese in Africa

In 1483, the Portuguese explorer Diogo Cao entered the Kingdom of Kongo, north of modern Angola, and found religious beliefs profoundly unlike Christianity. Cao, and the Christian missionaries who came in his wake, described nkisi (see

opposite), objects that the Africans believed were inhabited or possessed by spirits, as *feitiço*. Anglicized into “fetish,” the term became a general label for African magical artifacts.

Such an oversimplification of a complex religious landscape was a characteristic of European reactions to native spirituality. The Kongo *nganga*, diviner-healers who were said to defend the living against malevolent spirits and cure diseases, were labeled by Europeans as sorcerers, while their practice of harnessing the *bakisi* (spirits) by using *nkisi* led to them being accused of devil worship.

Spanish perspectives

In Central and South America, the Spanish encountered religious systems with state-operated hierarchies and public temples. The Franciscan missionaries who arrived in Mexico in 1524 were horrified to hear of human sacrifice (despite their own Christian notions of the self-sacrifice of God's son): the Mesoamerican peoples believed that the gods had sacrificed themselves to ensure the welfare of humankind and now required a blood offering in return. The Spanish branded such public sacrifice idolatry, and personal belief in divination and spirits *brujería* (witchcraft).

Missionaries were most concerned about native practitioners of magic arts, such as the *nahualli*, shape-shifters who were said to turn themselves into pumas or jaguars, and the *tlahuipochin*, necromancers reputed to have the power to spit fire. Yet despite



“The *nahualli* is ... a witch, who frightens people at night and sucks blood from children.”